



Get hold of your IP address here

STEP 5 Now, the great moment...click on Connect to start streaming. But how do you get people to hear your station? If you are on a LAN, find

out your IP address by typing **ipconfig** at the command prompt or right-click on the Network Neighbourhood and click on Properties. Then select TCP/IP from the list, and click on Properties. This will display your IP address. Take it down, and pass it on.

STEP 6 To tune into your station, ask everyone to click on the **Add File > Add URL** option from the playlist editor in Winamp (or any other MP3 player) and type in your IP address, followed by your port, in the following fashion: **http://128.128.6.54:8000/** where 128.128.6.54 is your IP address and 8000 is the port number.

STEP 7 Like to show off even more? Ask everyone to type in your IP address and port number on the browser address bar to open up your radio station home page.

What makes Shoutcast so good is that



Voila! Your radio station homepage!

you can stream many different kinds of soundfiles that are encoded to MP3 on the fly, doing away with multiple file conversions. While some Shoutcasts do skip or pause due to the bandwidth, for a service that is used by so many amateurs, the overall quality is impressive. Incidentally, Shoutcast stations generally host fewer listeners—typically, the largest stations have about 100 users. If you add more than 30 users to a medium size bandwidth, your server will soon creak with users complaining of bad audio quality. For more information, check out the documentation at <http://www.shoutcast.com/support/docs/>. There is also an open source version of this system called Icecast, which functions in a similar fashion. Based primarily for the Linux platforms, Icecast hasn't reached the level of popularity that Shoutcast has today.



CNET radio: all technical talk, all day long

news broadcasts from London in the darkest hours of World War II, or if you just want to go retro and deep into the last century, here is your chance. Old Time Radio (OTR) channels boast of rich historical content and can be found on Live365 and Shoutcast. Since amateurs host many of these sites, expect diverse content, with some channels focussing on the historical news broadcasts and others playing music that was then pop-

ular, and yet others streaming entire radio shows.

If you are a gaming enthusiast, tune in to XGR Radio (www.xgr.com), Internet's first all-day gaming radio station. Here you can catch breaking gaming news, interviews with gaming gurus and game makers, and game reviews. Shoutcast also features several stations that are dedicated to gaming.

If live music is more to your taste, try out the Shoutcast channels beaming out concert audios across a variety of genres. Finally, there is also the peer-to-peer version of radio. This is

at PeerCast (www.peercast.org), which uses the same Gnutella protocol that powers up file swapping services such as KaZaA, BearShare and eDonkey. PeerCast lets the broadcaster set up anonymous streaming broadcasts, which can be received by all those connected to the PeerCast client.

So now that you have all these options, you will need to compose a list of must-hear stations; most proprietary players let you maintain a list of stations

that you can access immediately. If you are using Winamp, you can bookmark your stations through the Bookmarks options.

A word of caution

A wet blanket to the gung-ho world of Net radio is the heavy royalty schedules slapped on the Internet-only radio stations. The argument is simple: if you are streaming out copyrighted music, you should pay. The RIAA (Recording Industry Association of America), bolstered by the American DMCA (Digital Millennium Copyright Act), wants artistes to get paid for these streams. The costs involved are now pushing many Web radio stations, including non-profit, university-based radio stations, out of business.

The quest for royalty payments started last year, with charges coming to 70 cents per song per thousand listeners (from when the stations have started broadcasts). A sum like this could spell the end for most, if not all, stations.

Recent moves in November 2002 have tried to change the fee structure. However, it appears that the consumer will end up paying for usage. Bigger stations are reconsidering their strategies and the smaller stations are slowly moving underground. The Internet community is fighting back through peer-to-peer technologies such as PeerCast that allow for anonymous broadcasting.

The immediate lookout, however, is brighter than it appears. Despite all the copyright and royalty wrangles, there is always going to be some amateur rebel broadcaster out there, using his desktop computer as a radio station. Shoutcast, MP3 and PeerCast have led to the boom of Internet radio broadcasting, but with the copyright laws kicking in, the fun is more muted these days.

With a lot of enthusiastic broadcasters and users, a modem user can easily tap into the gigantic radio Web, and all this just at the cost of connecting online.

The spirit of radio isn't dead; it's just been reincarnated. Internet radio breaks all the geographical boundaries and has no airwave signal strength issues. The future is pure music with the promise of high-quality audio and visual streaming entertainment. Video may have killed the radio star, but the Internet has regenerated it. ■

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